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Lawmakers close in on budget deal

\$56 billion plan backed by gas tax windfall and some election-year tax breaks

By Dan Petrella and Olivia Olander
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

SPRINGFIELD — Illinois lawmakers and Gov. JB Pritzker worked through the week-end ahead of a Sunday deadline to finalize a nearly \$56 billion election-year state spending plan that would be balanced, in part, with an anticipated windfall of sales tax revenue resulting from soaring gas prices.

Pritzker and fellow Democrats are building their November general election campaigns around the issue of affordability, blaming Republican President Donald Trump and his allies for cuts to social programs and for rising prices on necessities — most notably gasoline, which has jumped from an average of about \$2.91 per gallon in Chicago to \$4.82 since the Iran war began in late February.

But higher prices also mean more revenue for the state. Illinois collects a 6.25% tax on gas sales, and Democrats are moving to divert \$150 million of that windfall — money that otherwise would flow to mass transit — to help fund day-to-day state operations and

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State representatives work in the House chamber during the spring legislative session at the State Capitol on Sunday in Springfield. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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Last-ditch Bears stadium deal sought after collapse of Arlington Heights plan

By Rick Pearson and Jeremy Gorner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

SPRINGFIELD — Faced with the collapse of a yearslong tax relief plan aimed at encouraging a Chicago Bears move to Arlington Heights, state lawmakers spent Sunday, the last scheduled day of their spring session, scrambling for a Hail Mary plan that could get the votes to coerce the team to stay in Illinois.

For all of the Sundays that the Bears, one of the National Football League's charter franchises, have competed in their 105 years — from Decatur's Staley Field, then to Chicago's Wrigley Field and Soldier Field — it was an off-season Sunday, far away from the gridiron, that could prove to be one of the most consequential in team history.

In the wings stood an offer from the state of Indiana, which late last year created an agency to construct a taxpayer-financed stadium and surrounding mixed-use entertainment district for the Bears in Hammond, near Wolf Lake, 20 miles south-

See **BEARS** on Page A6



Eden Elling, from left, Anika Wicker and Adeline America talk before Trinity Christian College's final graduation on May 8. **VINCENT D. JOHNSON/FOR THE DAILY SOUTHTOWN**

Farewell to their alma mater

As several Illinois Christian colleges close or move, students and alums mourn the loss

By Angie Leventis Lourgos | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

They met on the first day of biology class about a decade ago at Trinity Christian College.

She asked if the open seat next to him was taken. They became lab partners for the rest of the semester.

About a year and a half later, Andrew Kowitz sent the young woman he met in biology on a romantic scavenger hunt laced with handwritten notecard clues scattered across the southwest suburban Palos Heights campus.

One stop was at South Hall, where he had asked her to be his girlfriend. Another was in the basement of Alumni Hall, where they had shared their first kiss.

The final destination was back at the science center, where Andrew Kowitz was waiting on one knee with an engagement ring in the exact spot where they once sat side by side during class.

"I said yes immediately," Casey Kowitz recalled.

The west suburban couple have two young children and celebrated their sixth wedding anniversary on Saturday.

Yet the college that brought them together is now shutting down.

Trinity's board of trustees announced in November that the private Christian liberal arts school would be closing at the end of this academic year, citing declining enrollment as well as financial constraints.

"The board has worked faithfully and tirelessly to consider every possible option in the face of significant and rapidly evolving financial challenges," said Jeanine Mozie, Trinity's acting president, in a video statement. "However, there is no sustainable path forward for our beloved institution."

The school's final commencement ceremony took place on May 8.

The news was surreal to many students and parents who had to scramble to make new arrangements for the next school year, as well as to generations of alums of the 67-year-old college who mourn the loss of their alma mater.

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NATION & WORLD

Trump toughens Iran terms

As negotiations to end the war drag on, a frustrated President Donald Trump has sent proposed changes back to Iran for consideration. **Page B1**

NATION & WORLD

Pentagon seeks AI

The Trump administration is pushing to unleash the power of artificial intelligence for the U.S. military while facing calls to put up guardrails. **Page B1**

ARTS & LIVING

Rocking out with the gods

The world premiere of "LOKI: The End of the World Tour" at Lifeline Theatre offers audiences a retro, rock-out experience. **Page B5**

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